ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

# THA 131: Basic Theatre Design and Crafts - Scenery, Lighting and Models

From a director's idea to a buildable, budgeted design

THEATRE & FILM

## Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

**Written for students, by students.**

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

**Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.**

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

# Why this pack exists

Design is a set of constraints solved creatively: text, space, budget, labour and safety. This pack covers design elements and principles, ground plans and models, materials and construction basics, lighting and sound roles, and how to present a design to a production team.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

## What you will be able to do

- Apply the elements and principles of design to a script's requirements.
- Produce a ground plan and a scale model for a short scene.
- Identify common scenery, lighting and sound equipment and their functions.
- Present a design with a budget and a build schedule.

## How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

## Elements and principles

Design language is learnable and assessable.

- Elements: line, shape, form, colour, texture and space.
- Principles: contrast, rhythm, unity, emphasis, pattern, movement, balance and scale.
- Start from the text: period, location, tone, entrances and required levels.
- Design for the audience's sightlines, not for a photograph.
- Every element should be justified by the production concept.
- A design that cannot be built within budget and time is not finished.

## Drawings, models and materials

Technical communication prevents expensive mistakes.

- Ground plan: viewed from above, to scale, with all entrances and furniture positions.
- Elevation and section: show heights and construction.
- Model: white card or foam board at 1:25 or 1:50, with a human figure for scale.
- Timber, plywood, canvas, steel and fabric each impose different construction rules.
- Paint and finish affect how lighting reads on stage.
- Label everything and include a materials list.

> **Safety is part of design**
> A platform that flexes, a rail that wobbles or a cable across a walkway is a failed design regardless of how it looks.

## Lighting, sound and presentation

Design is a collaborative department, not a solo artwork.

- Lighting shapes visibility, focus, mood and time of day.
- Common units: profile and fresnel lanterns, LED fixtures, dimmers and a control desk.
- Colour temperature and gels change how costume and paint read.
- Sound design covers reinforcement, effects and cues; know the difference between live and recorded sources.
- Present the concept, ground plan, model, materials list and budget on one board.
- Walk the production team through the design in five minutes without reading from notes.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

# Session record: THA 131

*2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026*

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

## 2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 131 Basic Theatre Design and Crafts: fundamentals of scene, sound, lighting, costume, make-up and masks
- Drawing, altering and repairing designs, accessories, building, painting, fitting, decorating and budgeting
- THA 132 Trends in Theatre Design and Technologies listed as the companion course

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

## 2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 131 Basic Theatre Design and Crafts, 3 credits, first semester
- THA 233 Design Concepts in Performance Spaces and THA 343 Set and Lighting Design appear at 200 and 300 level
- Design sequence spans all four years in this listing

*What changed: The 2019 listing adds THA 233 and THA 343, formalising the design sequence that the 2018 page described only in outline.*

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

## 2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Basic design and crafts remains the 100-level entry to the technology and design stress area
- Model making, ground plans and build budgeting are the assessed core
- Confirm workshop access rules and whether materials are supplied

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

*Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.*

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

## Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name the elements and principles of design.

Answer: Elements: line, shape, form, colour, texture, space. Principles: contrast, rhythm, unity, emphasis, pattern, movement, balance, scale.

2. Why is a ground plan essential?

Answer: It shows the arrangement of the stage from above to scale, allowing the director, designer and builder to agree on positions, levels and entrances.

3. What does a 1:25 model mean?

Answer: One unit on the model represents twenty-five of the same units in reality, for example 4 cm equals 1 m.

4. Give two functions of stage lighting.

Answer: Visibility and focus; mood, time of day and shaping the performance space are others.

5. What must accompany a design proposal?

Answer: A concept statement, ground plan, model, materials list, budget and build schedule.

## Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Analyse a script for location, period, entrances and levels.
- [ ] Draw a to-scale ground plan for one scene.
- [ ] Build a simple 1:50 model with a human figure for scale.
- [ ] List materials and costs for your design.
- [ ] Learn five lighting fixtures and their uses.
- [ ] Prepare a five-minute design presentation.
- [ ] Have your tutor review the plan for safety issues.

## Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

# Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

**Three ideas I can now explain without notes:**

**A question I still cannot answer:**

**For my lecturer or course rep:**

**Next revision action and date:**

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